Overview and grading

How the Writing section works, how your texts are graded and how the bands become your grade.

Total time	Tasks	Criteria	Tolerance
120 min	**2 tasks (~400 + ~250 words)**	**4 × 0–10**	**±10%**

THE WRITING SECTION

You have **120 minutes** for **two tasks**: one longer (~400 words, often an essay, but it can be another text type) and one shorter (~250 words). Writing is one of four equally weighted sections of the written exam, alongside Reading, Listening and Language in Use.

> A time split that works: ~65 min for the 400-word task (incl. 5–10 min planning) · ~40 min for the 250-word task · ~15 min to proofread both. Write your finishing times on the task sheet before you start.

At AHS, dictionaries and reference works – electronic ones included – are not allowed anywhere in the standardised exam. The tasks are written so that B2 vocabulary is enough. When you cannot think of a word, explain it in other words.

THE TEXT TYPES AT AHS

Text type	Word count	Register	Title?	Key feature
Essay	~400 words (360–440)	Formal	Required	Argue your position with evidence
Article	~250 or ~400 words	Depends on the audience	Required – catchy!	Write for real readers
Report	~250 or ~400 words	Formal and neutral	Subject line + section headings	Present findings and recommend action
Blog	~250 or ~400 words	Informal to semi-formal	Post only (not a comment)	Personal voice, invite interaction
E-mail	~250 words (225–275)	Usually formal	Required	Clear purpose, proper format

Word count tolerance: ±10%. That is 360–440 words for 400-word tasks and 225–275 for 250-word tasks. If your text is more than 10% too long or too short, Task Achievement drops by one band.

Almost every task lists three content points (the three bullet points in the task). Give each one its own body paragraph. With the introduction and the conclusion, every text has exactly five paragraphs. Register means how formal or casual your language is, for example a letter to a company compared with a message to a friend.

HOW YOU ARE GRADED: THE FOUR CRITERIA

Each text is rated on the official analytic scale: four criteria, each scored 0–10 and weighted equally, so a stronger criterion can make up for a weaker one. Band 6 is the B2 minimum in each criterion.

01 Task Achievement (Erfüllung der Aufgabenstellung)

All content points covered with supporting detail; text type conventions followed; appropriate title/greeting/closing; word count within ±10%.

02 Coherence and Cohesion (Kohärenz und Kohäsion)

Clear overall structure; effective paragraphing; logical development; variety of linking words; clear relationships between sentences.

03 Lexical and Structural Range (Spektrum sprachlicher Mittel)

Variety of vocabulary and structures; complex sentence forms; not repeating the same phrases; appropriate register; not lifting from the prompt.

04 Lexical and Structural Accuracy (Sprachrichtigkeit)

Grammar control; correct word choice; spelling; punctuation; accurate use of linking words.

> **Veto rule.** If a text does not address the task as a whole (for example an off-topic or learnt-by-heart text that ignores the prompt), the whole text gets 0. Writing the wrong text type alone does not trigger this. Read every task twice.

> **Don't play it safe with grammar.** A text built only on simple sentences cannot reach the upper Range bands, even if every sentence is correct. Use a passive, a conditional or a relative clause where it fits.

WHAT THE BANDS MEAN (SIMPLIFIED)

10 · Excellent

Everything the task asks for, fully developed with well-chosen details. Conventions confidently used, wide range of vocabulary and complex structures, only occasional slips.

8 · Good

All content points developed with relevant details. Clear structure, good range and variety, errors are rare and never cause misunderstanding.

6 · B2 minimum met

This is the B2 minimum (6/10): all content points developed but with limited supporting detail, a limited but appropriate set of linking words, enough range including some complex forms, and errors that do not get in the way of communication.

4 · Below B2

Content points addressed but not developed, mostly simple linear sentences, repetition and lifting from the prompt, or errors pile up beyond simple structures.

2 · Far below B2

Only parts of the task recognisable, very limited language, errors make parts of the text hard to understand.

0 · Not assessable / veto

No assessable performance – or the text fails to address the set task (see the veto rule above).

Simplified from the official B2 rating scale (2023 revision). The scale describes bands 0, 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10. The odd-numbered bands (1, 3, 5, 7, 9) are for texts between two descriptions. Your teachers grade with the full official scale.

FROM BANDS TO YOUR GRADE

1. Your two texts get **8 band scores** (2 texts × 4 criteria, each 0–10). That is 80 points at most, and both texts count the same.
2. They are converted into the **25 points** of the Writing section: your total ÷ 80 × 25. Reading, listening and language in use count 25 points each.
3. To pass, you need at least **60 of 100 points** overall and at least **25 points** in each area: reading + listening, and language in use + writing.

Points (of 100)	Grade (Note)
90 or more	Sehr gut
80 or more	Gut
70 or more	Befriedigend
60 or more	Genügend

Points (of 100)	Grade (Note)
under 60, or under 25 in one area	Nicht genügend

> Example: band 6 on all eight criteria is 48 of 80, which gives 15 of 25 points (60%). Band 6 is the B2 minimum. A weaker text can still be balanced by the other parts of the exam.

Source: the official correction and assessment guide for the written exam in modern foreign languages (BMB/IQS, September 2024). Your teachers apply it.

THE 8 MOST EXPENSIVE MISTAKES

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
Writing only 2 of 3 content points	Task Achievement drops sharply	Tick off each content point as you write it
Ignoring the text type's rules (e.g. a report without headings)	Task Achievement drops – conventions are part of the criterion	Check the Layout box in the guide before you start
Copying words from the prompt or the input material	Range drops: copied language does not count as your own	Rephrase, then interpret: what does the figure mean for your point?
Word count more than 10% too long or too short	Task Achievement drops one band	Count your words. Practise estimating.
Formal style in a blog (or vice versa)	Wrong register costs marks (it is not counted as an Accuracy error)	Decide: formal or informal? Then keep to it.
Only simple linking words	Low Coherence score	Use the B2 linking words table
No topic sentences	Paragraphs feel random, weak Coherence	First sentence of each paragraph = the point
Forgetting to proofread	Errors you would catch in 3 minutes	Keep about 15 minutes at the end